

3.2.1 2A Buddhism

Students are required to study aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Buddhism specified below and the different ways these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Buddhism.
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought). However students are expected to recognise and understand the following technical terms: Dukkha, Anicca, Nirvana, karma, ahimsa.

Section A: Buddhism

Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Buddha: the significance the life of Gautama Buddha for Theravada Buddhists with reference to his relevance as a role model and his authority as 'the enlightened one'; the Mahayana view that the life and teaching of Gautama Buddha was 'skillful means', with reference to the parable of the burning house in the Lotus Sutra.
- The meaning and relevance of Buddha's teaching about Dukkha, including the debate about whether Buddhism is pessimistic.
- The Pali Canon: the nature and authority of the Pali Canon; different views about how far this is an accurate record of Gautama Buddha's teaching and the relevance for Buddhists of this debate; the use of Pali Canon in worship and daily life.

Ultimate reality

- The key differences between the Theravada and Mahayana concepts of Buddha; the key features of the Trikaya doctrine in Mahayana Buddhism.
- Anicca: the meaning and importance of the concept of Anicca; the development of that idea in the Mahayana doctrine of emptiness.
- Nirvana: Nirvana in this life and after death; Nirvana as indescribable and beyond understanding; attempts in scripture to describe it and their strengths and weaknesses with reference to the 80th dilemma of the Questions of King Milinda.

Self, death and afterlife

- The meaning and purpose of life: better rebirth and Nirvana as goals of life and their relative importance; the ideal of the arhat and bodhisattva in Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism.
- Anatta (no-self): the concept of anatta; the five aggregates and the analogy of the chariot in the Questions of King Milinda, Book II chapter 1.1.
- Samsara: the cycle of birth, death and rebirth; the nature of karma and its role on the wheel of becoming; the realms of becoming and their significance including literal, metaphorical and psychological interpretations; Tibetan Buddhist beliefs about the 14th Dalai Lama as an expression of the Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara.

Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in the Buddhist way of life; the importance of intention; actions as kusala (healthy) or akusala (unhealthy); the extent of human free will and moral responsibility.
- The nature of the five precepts and the distinctive features of the six perfections of the Mahayana Buddhism.
- Ahimsa: the concept of ahimsa and its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child, treatment of animals and war, including the use of weapons of mass destruction; different Buddhist views.

Expressions of religious identity

- The Sangha: the monastic Sangha and its changing roles in Thailand; the traditional lifestyle and role of the Sangha in Thailand including its relationship with the lay community; the Sangha in the 21st century; the main features of the Wat Phra Dhammakaya movement.
- Devotion and its purposes: acts of devotion in Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism; the nature and role of Buddha images and the importance of making and sharing merit; the

different perspectives of Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism about the significance of worship.

- Meditation: the nature and purpose of meditation on the eightfold path; modern usage of Buddhist meditation as a form of therapy and how Buddhists have responded to this.

Buddhism, gender and sexuality

Historical and social factors that have influenced developments in Buddhist thinking about these issues with particular reference to Thailand, including: encounter with western lifestyles and values with the development of tourism after the 1980s; the changing roles of men and women in society outside of religion; the rights given to women by secular Thai governments.

Developments in Buddhist thought including feminist approaches:

- The debate leading to the revival of the Theravada order of nuns in the late 1990s.
- Continuing debates about female ordination and the role of women in Theravada Buddhism with reference to the work of Dhammananda and the Sakyadhita organisation.
- Different Buddhist views about celibacy, marriage and homosexuality and transgender issues.

Buddhism and science

How and why science has influenced Buddhism and how Buddhism has responded, with particular reference to: emphasis on evidence and reason in science; specific scientific discoveries; science as a stimulus to Buddhist ethical thinking.

Developments in Buddhist thought:

- How scientific explanation has challenged belief in karma and in miracles and Buddhist responses to that challenge.
- The value of science: the Buddha's attitude to the search for answers to unanswerable questions; the belief that science agrees with some Buddhist teaching with particular reference to quantum physics; the views of Thich Nhat Hanh and the 14th Dalai Lama about the relationship between Buddhism and science.
- Different Buddhist responses to ethical issues raised by science: genetic engineering.

Buddhism and the challenge of secularisation

This topic may be studied with exclusive reference to the British context.

Challenges of secularisation including: the replacement of religion as the source of truth and moral values; relegation of religion to the personal sphere; the rise of militant atheism: the view that religion is irrational.

Developments in Buddhist thought:

- Buddhist responses to materialistic secular values: the value of wealth and possessions.
- The preservation of traditional forms of Buddhism with reference to Amaravati and the Forest Tradition; the emergence of new forms of Buddhism with reference to Triratna and Secular Buddhism; the appeal of some forms of Buddhism as an alternative to other forms of religious expression.
- Emphasis on the contribution of Buddhism to society: including the principles and work of Engaged Buddhism as a liberationist approach in supporting the poor and oppressed.
- Comparison between the significant ideas of Stephen Batchelor and David Brazier about the nature of Buddhism.

Buddhism, migration and religious pluralism

How migration has created multicultural societies which include Buddhism, with particular reference to the development of Buddhism in Britain; diversity within the Buddhist community in Britain; freedom of religion as a human right in European law and religious pluralism as a feature of modern secular states. The influence of this context on Buddhist thought.

Developments in Buddhist thought:

- How far Buddhism should be seen as a collection of different traditions with little in common, with reference to two contrasting forms of Buddhism.
- Edict 12 of Ashoka on attitudes to other faiths; Buddhist attitudes to religious pluralism with reference both to diversity within Buddhism and diversity between religions, including the views of Nichiren Buddhism.
- Buddhist responses to issues of freedom of religious expression in society.

Section B: Dialogues

This section of the specification is focused on the connections between various elements of the course and requires students to develop breadth and depth in their understanding of the connections between the knowledge, understanding and skills set out in the specification. There are two areas for study, firstly the dialogue between Buddhism and philosophy: how developments in belief have, over time, influenced and been influenced by philosophical studies of religion, secondly the dialogue between Buddhism and ethics: how developments in belief have influenced and been influenced by ethical studies.

Students will be required to demonstrate a critical awareness of these connections and to analyse their nature.

The dialogue between Buddhism and philosophy

Beliefs and teachings about:

- ultimate reality
- self, death and afterlife
- sources of wisdom and authority
- religious experience
- the relationship between scientific and religious discourses
- the truth claims of other religions
- miracles.

The following issues, and the impact of the discussion on religious belief past and present, should be considered:

- How far the belief is reasonable – that is based on reason and/or consistent with reason.
- How meaningful the statements of faith are, and for whom.
- How coherent the beliefs are, and how consistent with other beliefs within the belief system.
- The relevance of philosophical enquiry for religious faith, with particular reference to the debate about the nature of faith as ‘belief in’ or ‘belief that’.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.

The dialogue between Buddhism and ethics

- Buddhist responses to the following approaches to moral decision-making in the light of key Buddhist moral principles:
 - deontological, with reference to Kant
 - teleological and consequential, with reference to Bentham
 - character based, with reference to virtue ethics.
- How far Buddhist ethics can be considered to be deontological, teleological, consequential, or character based.
- Buddhist responses to: the issues of human life and death and issues of animal life and death prescribed for study; theft and lying; marriage; homosexuality and transgender issues; genetic engineering.
- Buddhist responses to issues surrounding wealth, tolerance and freedom of religious expression.
- Buddhist understandings of free will and moral responsibility, and the value of conscience in Buddhist moral decision-making.

The impact of other ethical perspectives and ethical studies on Buddhist views about these issues, both past and present. This may include challenges to and support for Buddhist views; compatibility of Buddhist views with those of other ethical perspectives; the relative strengths and weaknesses of Buddhist perspectives and the other ethical perspectives studied on these issues; the implications of criticisms of Buddhist ethical teaching for the religion as a whole and its sources of authority.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.